



## UMBRIA ITALY

## Buried Treasure in Umbria

The dramatic, mountainous landscapes of Umbria in central Italy have inspired some of the world's greatest artists, including Michelangelo, Giotto, and Fra Angelico. Medieval and Renaissance towns tumble down its mountainsides like living history, many hiding exquisite art. In the fertile soil, hunters look for another Italian treasure: the knobby fungi known as truffles.



Beautiful enough to make painters of us all, Umbria seems to hide a masterpiece in every little church and chapel. It produced more saints than any other part of Italy, including St. Francis of Assisi, whose kind friendliness seems to live on in the spirit of Umbrians today. This landlocked region of Italy has witnessed the passage of marching armies, pilgrims, and traders over the centuries, but remains supremely hospitable to those wishing to admire its landscape, art, and rare, regional produce.

The culture and economy here are based on farming and hunting. In southeastern Umbria, the splendid towns of Spoleto and Norcia are surrounded by countryside, some carefully cultivated, some still wild and wooded as of old. From December to March, when dawn mists cloak the hills and valleys, a curious but well-rehearsed pas de deux performance takes place in this wondrous landscape. A solitary hunter sets out with his dog across a field of stubble lined with pale, pencil-thin birch trees. The animal sniffs the clay earth, its olfactory senses trained to pick up the scent from the prized *Tuber melanosporum*: the black truffle. Unearthed and cleaned, these deeply aromatic rhizomes become a transformational ingredient.

The sophisticated Romans and ancient Greeks revered truffles for their therapeutic and aphrodisiacal properties, and believed they were created as a result of the sacred thunderbolts that Jupiter periodically hurled to Earth. In reality, the Umbrian *tartufo nero* (black truffle) is a rather dull, woody fungus that needs a light brushing to remove the dirt clinging to it. Its otherworldly qualities are not evident until it is cut and tasted – at which point the all-pervading aroma of the freshly cut tuber translates into a fleeting moment of gustatory heaven that is rarely matched.

Less prized than the white truffles of Piedmont, which have sold in the past for prices exceeding €100,000 per kilo, the aromatic black truffle is still a rarity with the capacity to amaze. Though never cooked, the raw truffle is occasionally warmed, and in Umbria it is popularly grated sparingly over simple, hot pasta, such as *stringozzi*, an Umbrian form of pasta that's akin to spaghetti. The only other ingredient is a drizzle of olive oil, and Umbria boasts the best in Italy – all of its olive oils have DOP (“*denominazione origine protetta*”) status. Black truffle is also used sparingly in the region's almost indefinably good meat and fish dishes, and in risotto – whose simplicity belies the glorious taste that awaits, courtesy of Umbria's “black diamonds.”

### Three Days in Umbria

Umbria is an Italian Renaissance painting come to life. Its medieval hilltop towns and stunning countryside provide many opportunities for great sightseeing and dining.

**DAY ONE** Spend the morning in the lovely walled town of **Norcia**, birthplace of St. Benedict. Try the delis – the butchers here are so renowned they gave Italy its word for butcher: “*norcino*.” Take an afternoon bus to **Preci**, where pastel houses dot the steep hillside, and walk on to the splendid nearby abbey of **Sant'Eutizio**.

**DAY TWO** Magnificent **Spoleto** is dense with captivating buildings where the Roman, medieval, and Renaissance periods are pieced together. Unmissable sights are the open-air **Teatro Romano** and the **Ponte delle Torri**, a spectacular stone bridge.

**DAY THREE** Drive up to the breathtaking spread of the **Piano Grande**, the basin of an ancient subsided lake. It is crowned by the rugged peaks of the **Sibillini mountain range** in one of Italy's newest National Parks, and pans out below the iconic village of **Castelluccio di Norcia**, the perfect starting point for a walk in the park.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

There are **trains** and **buses** to the area from Perugia, the closest international airport.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Fonte Antica** (inexpensive) offers B&B within a 700-year-old farmhouse in the National Park of Monti Sibillini. [www.fonteantica.com](http://www.fonteantica.com)

**Hotel agli Scacchi** (moderate) in Preci has home comforts and a swimming pool. [www.hotelaglisacchi.com](http://www.hotelaglisacchi.com)

**Hotel Gattapone** (expensive) is a boutique hotel in Spoleto. [www.hotelgattapone.it](http://www.hotelgattapone.it)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

[www.english.regioneumbria.eu](http://www.english.regioneumbria.eu)

